

PRIVACY GUIDE

5 Places Hidden Cameras Hide in Airbnbs

A practical 12-second checklist for every traveler. Read once, use everywhere you stay.

Why this matters

Hidden cameras in short-term rentals aren't rare. They get found regularly in Airbnbs, hotel rooms, and vacation properties. Hosts hide them in everyday objects so they blend in. Spending 12 seconds checking on arrival is the cheapest privacy insurance available.

The 5 most common hiding spots

01 · Smoke detectors and CO alarms

The most common spot. A real smoke detector has one lens (the test light). If you see two, or a tiny extra circle pointing into the room — that's a camera. Detectors normally point straight down, not at the bed.

02 · Alarm clocks and USB chargers

Cheap "spy clocks" sold on Amazon look exactly like normal radios. The lens is usually a black pinhole on the face. USB-charger cameras hide the lens on the side near the prongs. Unplug it — if power runs through it when nothing's charging, suspicious.

03 · Mirrors (two-way)

The flashlight test: hold a flashlight against the mirror. A real mirror reflects the beam and shows a thick gap between glass and image. A two-way mirror lets the beam pass through and reveals what's behind. Better: use the magnetic detector — electronics behind the mirror produce a field.

04 · Air vents, fans, and AC



Cameras get embedded in vent grilles and fan housings. The lens points downward through the slats. Look for a tiny dot, slightly darker than the rest of the slat. Move the air filter aside if you can.

05 · Books, plants, and decor

Hollowed-out books on a shelf, fake plants, picture frames. If something is positioned with a perfect line of sight to the bed or shower — that's the cue. Books that don't belong on a vacation-rental shelf.

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3 APPS · BUILT FOR IPHONE

THE 12-SECOND CHECK

Use this every time you arrive

1. Open Spy Camera Finder. Tap Start Full Scan.
2. Wi-Fi sweep flags unknown devices on the local network.
3. Bluetooth radar picks up nearby BLE trackers and beacons.
4. Magnetic field detector finds electronics behind walls/mirrors.
5. Infrared filter reveals night-vision lenses invisible to the eye.
6. Walk the room slowly while the app scans. Watch for spikes near vents, mirrors, alarm clocks.
7. If something flags — photograph it, contact the platform (Airbnb/host), request a full refund.

What to do if you find something

Don't touch it or move it. Photograph the device and its location. Contact the platform support immediately (Airbnb has a 24/7 Trust line). Most platforms refund the entire booking and may issue travel credit. Local police can also be involved if the device was actively recording.

Get Spy Camera Finder

apps.apple.com/us/app/spy-camera-finder-scanner/id6760315795